

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Themes)

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H

Hardened Hearts

The book of Exodus often mentions that the Lord caused Pharaoh to act stubborn or “hardened Pharaoh’s heart” (Exodus 4:21; 9:12; 10:1, 20; 11:10; 14:4, 8). These statements can be difficult. Did God make Pharaoh sin?

These factors are important to consider:

1. The Lord knew Pharaoh would be stubborn (3:19).
2. Pharaoh himself became stubborn (8:15, 32).
3. Pharaoh stayed stubborn despite clear warnings (8:19).

Pharaoh was not a well-meaning person, simply misguided and not allowed to repent. Although God controlled the situation, Pharaoh was responsible for his actions.

This interaction between human choice and divine control (God’s sovereignty) appears in other parts of Scripture. The Israelites became stubborn and did not trust God in the wilderness (Psalm 95:8–10). God hardened the hearts of the Canaanites, so they did not seek peace with the Hebrews (Joshua 11:20). The message God gave to the prophet Isaiah caused his listeners to become stubborn (Isaiah 6:9–10).

In a similar way, in the New Testament, many people stubbornly refused to respond with faith to the good news about Jesus (Matthew 13:15; John 12:40; Acts 28:27). People are responsible for their choices, but they do not make them in isolation. They make choices within the world God created and guides.

The book of Exodus emphasizes God’s control over Pharaoh. It shows a clear contrast between two belief systems. Pharaoh thought he was a god and could do anything he wanted. But God proved this was not true. Like all created beings, Pharaoh’s choices were limited. God showed that only he is truly independent. The Lord is the eternal “I Am” (see 3:6–14; 6:2–8; 20:2; 34:6–7; Isaiah 45:3–7; 48:17; Mark 14:62; John 8:23–28).

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 8:21; Exodus 3:19; 4:21; 8:15, 19, 32; 9:12; 10:1, 20; 11:10; 14:4, 8; Joshua 11:19–20; 2 Chronicles 36:11–13; Psalm 95:8–11; Isaiah 6:9–10; Ezekiel 11:18–21; 36:22–27; Matthew 12:34–35; 13:10–17; Luke 8:4–15; John 12:37–40; Acts 28:23–28; Romans 2:14–16; 11:7–12; 2 Corinthians 3:13–18; Ephesians 4:17–24; Hebrews 3:6–19; 6:4–8

“He Will Come”

Jesus promised his followers that he would return to bring them to be with him forever (John 14:1–3). Right after Jesus ascended to heaven, the apostles received a message that he would come back one day (Acts 1:9–11). In the visions described in the book of Revelation, John hears Jesus promise to return again (Revelation 22:6–20).

The final completion of everything, “the Day of the Lord” (2 Thessalonians 2:2), will come as a surprise, “like a thief in the night” (1 Thessalonians 5:2). Jesus said “only the Father” knows when that day will be (Matthew 24:36; Acts 1:6–7). Now is a time for hope and confidence, not guessing. Christians should not set dates and times for the end.

When the Bible teaches about future events (what will happen at the end of time), it gives us two important things: hope during difficult times and wisdom for how to live now. The Bible’s teaching about the end times, also called eschatology (the study of what will happen in the future), helps us focus on living faithfully today. Instead of worrying about exactly when these events will occur, we should concentrate on how we live now.

The apostle Paul describes events like “the rebellion” and the appearance of “the man of lawlessness” that will happen before “the Day of the Lord” (2 Thessalonians 2:1–12). Yet, he does not focus on the details. Instead, he reminds his audience of these events to refute false teachings and encourage Christians who suffer for the faith (2 Thessalonians 1:3–10; 2:5).

When Christ returns, he will:

- defeat the enemies of the good news about Jesus (the gospel)
- save suffering Christians (2 Thessalonians 1:7–10)
- gather his followers to be with him forever (1 Thessalonians 4:13–17)

This future event requires a response now. Those who accept the good news and live for God can be confident of rescue. Those who reject God will experience eternal destruction. God’s choice and calling of Christians is their hope and comfort (2 Thessalonians 2:13–14). They can remain steady now as they look to the future (2:14–15). They have a guarantee of the outcome when he returns.

Passages for Further Study

Matthew 25:1–46; Acts 1:6–7; 1 Thessalonians 4:13–5:11; 2 Thessalonians 1:7–10; 2 Thessalonians 2:1–12

The Heart in the Psalms

The Hebrew words *leb* and *lebab* both mean “heart.” But these words are difficult to translate. They rarely refer to the physical human heart. Instead, these terms usually refer to the center of a person’s being. They represent a person’s thoughts, reflections, will, and motives. The story of someone’s heart shows their commitment and the direction of their life.

The psalms speak a lot about the heart. The hearts of evil people are clever and full of schemes (Psalm 58:2; 64:6; 140:2). They are deceptive, hypocritical, greedy, jealous, and lack honesty (10:3; 28:3; 41:6; 55:21; 62:4; 141:4). Over time, they become more arrogant, careless, and stubborn (14:1; 17:10; 73:7; 78:8; 81:12; 95:8, 10; 101:5; 119:70). Evil people are only loyal to themselves (78:37). Their harmful way of life leads to their own destruction (5:9).

Meanwhile, the writers of the psalms openly express their sorrow, trouble, suffering, and desperation (13:2; 22:14; 25:17; 38:8, 10; 40:12; 55:4; 61:2; 69:20; 73:21, 26; 109:22; 143:4; 147:3). Through their pain, their hearts grow. Their character becomes stronger, and their relationship with God deepens because of these painful experiences. They pray intensely (62:8; 119:145). They desire God (84:2). They trust in him (28:7). They invite God to examine their hearts or motives (7:9; 17:3; 26:2; 139:1–6, 23). Their commitment remains steady, and they have “a pure heart” (24:4; 51:10; 73:1, 13). They are content, even when humbled (131:1).

As God heals their broken hearts (their deep emotional pain, sorrow, or distress), they become strong and confident (34:17–18; 51:17; 27:3, 14; 31:24; 57:7; 108:1; 112:7–8; 138:3). They are full of life (22:26; 69:32). In the end, God satisfies them and fulfills what their hearts desire (20:4; 21:2; 37:4). This brings joy and praise to godly people (4:7; 9:1; 13:5; 16:7, 9; 19:8; 30:11–12; 33:21; 86:12; 89:50; 102:4; 105:3; 111:1; 119:7, 111; 138:1).

Passages for Further Study

Psalms 7:9; 9:1; 13:2; 14:1; 16:7–9; 17:3; 19:8; 20:4; 21:2; 22:14, 26; 24:4; 26:2; 27:3, 14; 28:3, 7; 33:21; 34:17–18; 37:4; 38:8, 10; 51:10, 17; 55:4, 21; 57:7; 58:2; 61:2; 62:4, 8–10; 64:6; 69:20; 73:1, 7, 13, 21, 26; 78:8, 37; 81:12; 84:2; 86:12; 89:50; 95:8, 10; 102:4; 108:1; 109:22; 111:1; 119:70, 111, 145; 131:1; 138:1; 139:1–24; 140:2; 147:3

Holiness and Sexual Purity

The Bible teaches that people should be holy in their sexual relationships. God created humans as sexual beings. The first command God gave to Adam and Eve was to “Be fruitful and multiply” (Genesis 1:28). This means they should have children. After sin entered

the world, the good things God created (including sex) became easily misused or corrupted.

Scripture contains many examples of sexual sin. God called his people to be holy. The Israelites received many commands that linked sexuality with holiness (see, for example, Leviticus 18:1–30). The sexual purity of God’s people faced serious challenges in the land of Canaan, where many wrong sexual practices were common. Many times, the Israelites failed to follow God’s standards for sexual purity.

The believers who received Paul’s letters also lived in places where wrong sexual behavior was common. Unlike the sexual freedom of the Greco-Roman world, God’s people were called to be faithful and pure in their sexual lives (1 Thessalonians 4:3–8). Sexual relationships should only happen within marriage (1 Corinthians 7:1–9, 36–37).

God has made Christians holy through the work of his Holy Spirit (1 Corinthians 6:11; 2 Thessalonians 2:13). Because of this, Christians are called to live as God’s holy people (1 Corinthians 1:2). God has given them everything they need to live a holy life in this world (2 Peter 1:3–4). As a result, Christians should live differently from the unholy world around them. Every part of their life should show the changing work of the Holy Spirit (Romans 12:2).

Sexual relations outside of marriage are not right for anyone who is united with Christ. This kind of behavior harms the Christian’s body, which has become a holy place where God lives and therefore belongs to God (1 Corinthians 6:12–20).

Though homosexual activity was accepted in Greco-Roman culture, the church has traditionally understood the Bible to condemn it. In both the Old Testament and the New Testament, homosexual activity is described as going against God’s plan for men and women (Leviticus 18:22; 20:13; Romans 1:25–27; 1 Corinthians 6:9–11; 1 Timothy 1:8–11).

Paul strongly warns that people who freely persist in wrong sexual relations, whether homosexual or heterosexual, will not inherit the kingdom of God but will face God’s judgment (1 Corinthians 6:9–10; Galatians 5:19–21; Colossians 3:5–6; see also 2 Peter 2:1–3:13). However, like all sins, forgiveness and cleansing are offered to anyone who turns to Christ with faith and repentance (Acts 2:38; Romans 3:21–26; see 1 Corinthians 6:11). Those who follow Jesus Christ are called to show love, kindness, and mercy to others (Matthew 7:1–2; Ephesians 4:32; Colossians 3:12–14). God’s people should live in holiness and godliness, in agreement

with the desires of their Creator and Judge (2 Peter 3:11-13).

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 2:18-25; Leviticus 18:1-30; Leviticus 20:10-24; Romans 12:1-2; 1 Corinthians 1:2; 1 Corinthians 6:9-20; 1 Corinthians 7:1-9, 14; Galatians 5:16-24; Colossians 3:1-6; 1 Thessalonians 4:3-8; 1 Peter 1:13-16; 2 Peter 1:3-4

Holiness by Relationship

Holiness refers to God's transcendent nature and moral purity (Leviticus 10:3). God is completely set apart from everything else. God is pure, perfect, and greater than all. But we are limited creatures who sin. So how can we be holy as God is holy?

We can never become transcendent like God. We will always be finite creatures, and our holiness will never be absolute like God's. Therefore, our holiness does not come from our own nature or character. Instead, it comes from our union with God and the transformative power of God's grace.

When God declares a place to be holy, it is because God makes his presence known there (see Exodus 3:5). God declared objects holy, like the altar in the tabernacle (Exodus 29:44-46). The objects are holy because God instructed them to be built a certain way and accepted them for his service. Their connection to God makes them holy in a unique way.

It is the same for people. We are told to be holy because God is holy (Leviticus 19:2; 1 Peter 1:15-16). Only God can give holiness to humans. Without a relationship with God, true holiness is impossible, no matter how good, religious, or disciplined someone's life is. Only God can make people holy (Exodus 31:13; Leviticus 20:8; 22:32). God promises to be with his people and make their holiness possible (Hosea 11:9; see Isaiah 35:8-10).

The church, like Israel in the Old Testament, has a special relationship with God. Because we are adopted as God's children, we can become godly people (see Exodus 4:22; Romans 8:14; Galatians 3:26; 1 John 3:2). Jesus, the Holy One, died for us, making it possible for everyone who believes in him to have a right relationship with God (Romans 5:12-21). This relationship is the foundation of our holiness (see 1 Corinthians 6:11). We can be holy in our relationship with God and in how we treat others. But it can only happen through our connection to the holy God.

Passages for Further Study

Exodus 3:5; 20:8-11; 28:29-35; 29:44-46; 31:13; Leviticus 11:44-45; 19:1-3; 20:3-8; 22:32; Psalm 24:3-6; Isaiah 35:8-

10; Daniel 4:8-9; Romans 8:5-14; Galatians 3:2-3; 5:16-26; 1 Peter 1:13-16; 1 John 3:2-3

The Holiness of God's People

God called the people of Israel "to be holy" because he freed them from slavery in Egypt (see Leviticus 11:45). He also freed humanity through Jesus Christ, who paid the price to release us from slavery to sin and death (1 Peter 1:18). God paid the ultimate price to set humanity free, redeeming us "with the precious blood of Christ, a lamb without blemish or spot" (1:19). Through this sacrifice, God has purchased our freedom from the empty way of life that people experience before coming to Christ.

Holiness was at the center of the lifestyle that God required from his people under the old covenant (the agreement God made with Israel through Moses at Mount Sinai). God commanded them to "Be holy because I, the LORD your God, am holy" (see Leviticus 19:2). God had rescued his people from the control of a cruel, foreign nation that worshiped other gods. Now they were to live as God's people in the new land where he was bringing them.

The apostle Peter applies this same requirement to God's people of the new covenant (the agreement God made through Jesus Christ). This includes all who have come to God through faith in Jesus Christ. Peter writes, "just as He who called you is holy, so be holy in all you do," (1 Peter 1:15). This holiness has both a negative and a positive side.

Negatively, to be holy means to separate from this world. This means avoiding the ways of thinking and acting that are common among people who do not know God. We turn away from our old sinful lifestyle that we lived before becoming Christians. Because of their new identity in Christ, believers live as foreigners in this world (1 Peter 1:17). Their values are shaped by God's kingdom rather than earthly culture.

Positively, to be holy also means to be separate for God. This means we try to be like our Father in heaven and live according to the values of our new homeland, the kingdom of God.

Believers in Christ have been set free from the old, meaningless life and its values. We are to live as obedient children of our heavenly Father (1 Peter 1:14). Our Father has not only saved us because he loves us, but he also disciplines his children, just like a human father would. He will judge "each one's work impartially" (1:17).

Therefore, we must live before God "in reverent fear" (1:17). We must acknowledge his holiness and

majesty and strive by faith to reflect his holy character in our lives. Holiness is an essential part of the Christian life. While we are justified by faith, true faith naturally expresses itself in a life that reflects God's holiness (see James 2:14-26).

Passages for Further Study

Leviticus 10:3; 11:44-45; 19:2; Isaiah 29:17-24; 1 Corinthians 6:9-20; Hebrews 12:1-13; 1 Peter 1:15-18; Revelation 21:5-8; 22:14-15

The Holy One of Israel

The phrase The Holy One of Israel appears in the prophecy of Isaiah about 24 times. The Holy One is "the King" (Isaiah 6:5). The righteous and just one is the God without equal (26:7; 40:25). He is the redeemer of his people (41:14).

Anyone approaching the Holy One must worship him with reverence and awe. The Holy One associates himself with Mount Zion. It is holy because it is his symbolic home (see 18:7; 24:23; 27:13; 56:7; 60:1-22).

The Holy One of Israel is different from all creation because he is morally perfect creator. Sinful people cannot live with him (see Isaiah 1:4). God's holiness requires ceremonial purity and moral perfection. God is like a consuming fire that removes anything not connected to his holy will (see 33:14).

Yet the Holy One of Israel reserves a small group of people for himself (Isaiah 4:2-3; 6:13). He spiritually cleanses them and promises to be with his own redeemed people (12:6; 35:8-9; 62:12; see also 49:7). He shows his holy power by helping sinful and weak humans. He saves them from the exile caused by their sin, and opening the new creation for them.

Passages for Further Study

Psalms 71:22-23; 78:41; Proverbs 9:10; Isaiah 6:1-5; 10:17, 20; 17:7; 29:17-24; 30:15; 41:14, 17-20; 43:1-4, 10-21; 48:17-18; 54:4-5; 55:5; 57:15; Jeremiah 50:29; 51:5; Ezekiel 39:7-8; Hosea 11:8-9; Habakkuk 3:3-6; John 6:66-69; Acts 2:27; 13:35; Revelation 16:5-7

The Holy Spirit's Presence

The book of Acts emphasizes the presence and power of the Holy Spirit. Before the Spirit came, Jesus spoke about the Spirit's influence on his followers (1:8; see John 14:15-17, 26; 15:26; 16:7-15). The Spirit clearly guided the early church in selecting Spirit-filled leaders to care for the needs of the Hellenistic widows (Acts 6:1-7). These were Greek-speaking Jewish widows who needed help in the daily distribution of food. The Holy Spirit chose the apostles Barnabas and Saul for

missionary work (13:1-5). When the first church council met to discuss the membership of non-Jewish people (gentiles), they followed the Spirit's direction (15:28).

The Holy Spirit filled Christian workers Stephen and Philip to preach with the Spirit's power (Acts 6:1-8:40). The Spirit energized the apostle Paul's ministry from the start (9:17). In the book of Acts, the church increased and expanded under the Holy Spirit's guidance and power (for example, 2:4, 41-47; 4:31; 5:32; 8:15, 17, 29; 9:31). Because of the Spirit's important role in Acts, people often call it "the Acts of the Holy Spirit."

The Holy Spirit acts in many ways:

- The Holy Spirit gives and restores life (Genesis 2:7; Psalm 104:24-30; Ezekiel 37:1-14; Joel 2:28-32; Romans 8:9-11).
- The Holy Spirit calls and chooses workers for Christ's service (Acts 13:2; 20:28).
- The Holy Spirit directs God's servants where and when he wants them to act (Acts 8:29; 9:15; 10:19-20; 11:12; 16:6; 1 Corinthians 2:13; 1 Peter 1:12).
- The Holy Spirit inspired the writing of Scripture (2 Timothy 3:16-17; 2 Peter 1:20-21).
- The Holy Spirit teaches the church Christ's message (John 14:26; 1 Corinthians 12:3).
- The Holy Spirit shows the power of the good news about Jesus (the gospel) through miraculous signs and wonders (Acts 14:3; Hebrews 2:4).
- The Holy Spirit teaches God's people the truths of Scripture (Acts 1:16; Hebrews 9:8; 10:15-17; 1 Peter 1:11-12).
- The Holy Spirit testifies about Jesus and brings him glory (John 15:26; 16:13-14).
- The Holy Spirit makes people aware of their sins and their need for the good news (John 16:8).
- The Holy Spirit warns them against becoming stubborn (Hebrews 3:7-11, 15).
- The Holy Spirit gives gifts to God's people (1 Corinthians 12:4-11).
- The Holy Spirit empowers them to share the good news, serve the Lord, and work for God's kingdom.

Passages for Further Study

John 14:15-17, 26; 15:26; 16:7-15; Acts 1:8, 16; 2:4, 41-47; 4:31; 5:32; 6:1-7; 8:15, 17, 29; 9:15, 17, 31; 10:19-20; 11:12; 13:1-5; 14:3; 15:28; 16:6; 20:28; 1 Corinthians 2:13; 12:1-11; Ephesians 1:13-14; 2 Timothy 3:16-17; Hebrews 2:4; 3:7-11, 15; 9:8; 10:15-17; 1 Peter 1:11-12; 2 Peter 1:20-21

The Holy Spirit's Work

Different New Testament writers emphasized various aspects of the Holy Spirit's work. The apostle John, for example, emphasized the Spirit's role as a teacher

and revealer of God's thoughts and ways (John 14:17, 26; 15:26; 16:13–15; 1 John 2:20, 27). The apostle Luke focused on the Spirit's guidance and power for spreading the Christian message (Acts 1:8; 4:8–12, 31; 8:29–40; 13:9–12). Meanwhile, the apostle Paul provided a broad perspective of the Spirit's work.

Paul teaches that God gives the Holy Spirit to everyone who enters a saving relationship with Jesus Christ (1 Corinthians 6:19; Galatians 3:2–5; Ephesians 1:13–14). The Spirit brings new life in Christ and confirms the salvation of Christians and their identity as God's children (1 Corinthians 6:11; 2 Thessalonians 2:13; Romans 8:9, 14–17).

The Holy Spirit gives Christians:

- power over sin (Romans 8:1–4);
- power to live the Christian virtues (Galatians 5:22–23); and
- power to serve in Christian ministry (1 Corinthians 12:1–31).

Christians must “be filled with the Holy Spirit” (Ephesians 5:18). They may encounter a struggle between their human desires and the Spirit. But, they can please God by obeying the Spirit's guidance and strength (Galatians 5:16–18).

The Holy Spirit helps Christians understand God's thoughts and ways (1 Corinthians 2:9–16). He provides spiritual gifts to Christians to support the church's overall health (12:1–31). The Spirit guides and strengthens worship as Christians use the gifts given by him (14:26–33, 39–40).

The Holy Spirit guarantees that Christians will receive all the blessings God has promised (2 Corinthians 1:21–22; 5:1–5; Ephesians 1:13–14). The Spirit supports Christians and prays for them when they are weak (Romans 8:26–27). The Spirit's goal is to make Christians “conformed to the image of” God's Son (Romans 8:28–29).

Passages for Further Study

John 14:15–17, 26; 15:26; 16:7–15; Acts 1:8; 2:4; 5:32; 6:1–7; 8:29, 39; 9:31; 13:1–5; 14:3; 15:28; 16:6; 20:28; Romans 8:1–4, 9, 14–17, 26–29; 1 Corinthians 2:9–16; 6:11, 19; 12:1–31; 14:1–33, 39–40; 2 Corinthians 1:22; 5:5; Galatians 3:5; 5:16–18, 22–23; Ephesians 1:13–14; 5:18; 2 Thessalonians 2:13; 2 Timothy 3:16–17; Hebrews 2:4; 3:7–11, 15; 9:8; 10:15–17; 1 Peter 1:11–12; 2 Peter 1:20–21; 1 John 2:20, 27

Holy War

The Israelites' total destruction of their enemies raises difficult questions about right and wrong. What reasons made Israel invade, conquer, and destroy

Canaan and its people? From a human perspective, Israel's aggressive invasions to conquer Canaan seem illegal and immoral. The Bible provides some insights into this issue. While these insights do not answer all our questions, they help us understand the situation better.

First, God commanded and led the war against the Canaanites, not humans. God was uniquely present with Israel (Exodus 19:5–6; 40:34–38). After Israel crossed the Jordan River, it was obvious that God fought against the Canaanites (Joshua 6). When God did not fight, Israel lost (Joshua 7). God defines morality based on his character. For ancient Israel, this meant removing evil to keep God present (Deuteronomy 7:1–6; Deuteronomy 20:16–18; see also Numbers 25; Judges 2:1–15).

Second, the people of Canaan had turned against God and become very evil (see, for example, Genesis 34:1–2). During the time of the patriarch Abraham, God said that the Canaanites' sins did not yet justify their destruction (Genesis 15:16). Now, several hundred years later, they did.

They were committing terrible crimes against God and humans. This included idol worship, child sacrifice, adultery, incest, murder, and oppression (see Leviticus 18). These sins completely defiled the land and its people, making them spiritually unclean (Leviticus 18:24–25). The holy God was exercising his justice against extreme evil.

It is important to understand that the war God allowed Israel to fight was limited to a specific time, place, and people. Wars fought in the name of religion are not justified by this example. For instance, the Crusades (military attacks by Europeans (who called themselves Christians) against Muslims in the Middle East during the years AD 1095–1291) were wrong. The same is true for recent violent attacks by people claiming to act for Islam (called jihads by those who carry them out).

Jesus plainly said, “Blessed are the peacemakers” (Matthew 5:9). He also said, “all who draw the sword will die by the sword” (Matthew 26:52). The Jews expected Jesus, as the Messiah (God's chosen leader), to lead Israel to military victory over the Romans. Instead, he sacrificed his life to defeat sin, death, and Satan.

God has reserved the right of judgment for himself (Romans 12:19). In the final judgment, he will express his holy anger and justice toward all the wrong and sinful actions of humanity (see Revelation 19:11–21; 20:7–10). Therefore, no one can now rightly claim that God has commanded the killing of a specific group of

people. In the modern world today, it is never just to commit genocide (killing or destroying an entire group of people on purpose).

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 12:1; 13:14–17; 15:16, 18–21; Deuteronomy 1:30; Deuteronomy 7:1–6, 16–26; 20:1–4, 10–18; 32:8–9; Judges 3:27–30; 1 Samuel 7:7–11; 2 Chronicles 13:12–19; 20:20–24; Isaiah 13:1–5; Joel 3:1–16; Matthew 5:9; 26:50–54; Revelation 19:11–21; 20:7–15

Hope Beyond Judgment

In the Bible, the prophets often proclaim messages of judgment and doom, but sometimes they also provide hope.

In the prophecy of Jeremiah, the first sign of hope is the Lord's command for Israel reject idolatry and obey the Lord God and the special agreement (the covenant) made at Mount Sinai (Jeremiah 3:11–4:2). If they responded correctly, there would be a positive future for them. They could experience healing salvation (3:22–23). Israel would become a blessing to all nations (4:1–2). The people's repentance would end God's punishment, and the nation would not face destruction. Even during difficulties before the destruction of Jerusalem, God promised a wonderful future that gave hope to the nation (see 16:15; 23:3–8; 29:10–14; 30:1–33:26).

Even after God allowed the destruction of Jerusalem, he provided hope to the exiles in Babylon. After seventy years, those who obeyed the Lord would return to the promised land to rebuild the temple and Jerusalem. An active community would experience peace and prosperity (see Jeremiah 46:27–28; chapters 50–51). After Persians conquered Babylon, the Jewish exiles would return to Judah. These events happened in 539–538 BC.

Hope for God's people extended far into the future, as God promised a righteous descendant of King David to rule over his people (Isaiah 11:1–5; Jeremiah 23:5–6; 33:15–17). Jesus Christ is that righteous descendant. Through his death on the cross, he became “the mediator of a new covenant” (Hebrews 9:13–15; 12:22–24). Those who trust in him now hope for his eternal kingdom beyond God's judgments in this age.

Passages for Further Study

Isaiah 2:3–4; 4:2; 11:1–16; 35:1–10; 52:11–12; Jeremiah 3:11–4:2; 16:14–15; 23:3–8; 29:10–14; 30:1–33:26; 46:27; Hosea 3:4–5; Amos 9:11–15; Hebrews 9:13–15; 12:22–24

Hope for the Messiah

In the first century, many Jews hoped the Messiah (God's chosen one) would come. They thought this rescuer would defeat Israel's enemies and bring peace and prosperity to God's people.

The Hebrew word “Messiah” and the Greek word “Christ” both mean “anointed one.” This term comes from the tradition of anointing Israelite kings with oil at their coronation. This act confirmed their role as God's representative to rule the nation. Later, the term referred to the future king for which Israel hoped.

Many people hoped for a king from David's family line to restore David's dynasty and rule with righteousness and justice in Jerusalem. This hope came from the special agreement (the covenant) God made in 2 Samuel 7:11–16. God promised King David that his descendants would rule forever. As Israel's kingdom decreased and eventually ended, Old Testament prophets predicted the coming of the Christ (Isaiah 9:6–7; 11:1–5; Jeremiah 23:5–6; 33:15–16; Ezekiel 37:24–25). This Christ would rescue God's people and rule forever as David's successor.

The gospel writers focus on showing that Jesus is the promised Christ (see, for example, Matthew 1:21–23; Luke 1:32–33, 69–70). Yet, he fulfilled these promises in an unexpected way. After Peter said Jesus is “The Christ of God,” Jesus began teaching about the Christ's suffering (Luke 9:20–22). As Jesus neared Jerusalem for the last time, people recognized him as, “the King who comes in the name of the Lord” (Luke 18:36–38; 19:36–38). Yet, later these same people rejected him (Luke 22:66–71). They crucified and mocked him as “THE KING OF THE JEWS” and “the Christ of God” (Luke 23:35–39).

On the third day, Jesus rose from the dead just as he said he would. During his appearances to the disciples, he explained that the Scriptures always prophesied that the Christ (or Messiah) would have to “suffer these things and then to enter His glory” (Luke 24:26). Jesus' death and resurrection confirm that he is truly the Christ. His death brings “repentance and forgiveness of sins” (24:46–47).

Passages for Further Study

2 Samuel 7:11–16; Isaiah 9:6–7; 11:1–5; Jeremiah 23:5–6; 33:15–16; Ezekiel 37:24–25; Luke 2:25–32; 3:15

The Household

The household was the basic family unit of Greco-Roman society. People believed that if households were stable, the state would also be stable. In these households, everyone had clear roles and responsibilities

that were deeply embedded in their culture. The main goal was to keep the “natural” order of authority and obedience. Breaking this order would lead to dishonor and corruption.

In this system, the husband-father-master was in charge of everyone. Men controlled public spaces and government, while women managed the home. Greco-Roman speakers often accused new foreign religions, like Christianity, of corrupting society by threatening the household structure.

The New Testament household codes were not new ideas (see Ephesians 5:21–6:9; Colossians 3:18–4:1; 1 Timothy 2:8–15; 5:1–2; 6:1–2; Titus 2:1–3:8; 1 Peter 2:18–3:7). The apostles adapted them to fit the Christian faith and address specific needs. The Christian faith often made major changes to the normal practices of culture. Yet, wisdom and carefulness were necessary. Ignoring the normal practices of culture could cause severe problems. This could bring dishonor, disgrace, and shame on the entire household—including Jesus, the head of the Christian household.

This was the effect of some false teachers in Ephesus, as discussed in the first letter to Timothy in the New Testament. In this context, the New Testament household codes helped Christian communities live in a way that:

1. stopped accusations that Christianity threatened the state; and
2. served as a strong, attractive witness to the truth.

Passages for Further Study

Ephesians 5:21–6:9; Colossians 3:18–4:1; 1 Timothy 2:8–15; 3:5, 12, 15; 5:1–2, 8; 6:1–2; Titus 2:1–3:8; 1 Peter 2:13–3:7; 4:17; 5:1–5

Human Confusion and God's Purpose

God is not missing or only occasionally involved in human lives. He actively determines events in the world to fulfill his purpose (Habakkuk 2:3, 14; see also Psalm 47:9; Acts 17:24–26; Colossians 1:15–20). The Lord is holy and merciful, acting in history to save his people (Habakkuk 3:2–15; see also Ephesians 1:3–10; 2 Peter 3:15). This is so that everyone can eventually experience his glory (Habakkuk 2:14).

Often, how God achieves his goals can confuse his people. This confusion is obvious in the prophetic book of Habakkuk. Habakkuk had an open relationship with God. The prophet felt free to share his honest concerns with the Lord. God did not criticize him for it.

From Habakkuk's perspective, God seemed inactive in the presence of violence and social injustice in Judah

(Habakkuk 1:2–4). God then revealed that he would act by bringing the Babylonians to punish Judah. They were a nation even more wicked than Judah (1:5–11). This confused Habakkuk even more. Yet, God's promise of justice and a vision of God's glory led the prophet to a firm faith and praise (3:16–19).

Habakkuk's spiritual journey is similar to many Christians. During times of doubt and discouragement, Christians can talk to the Lord and share their questions and concerns. He may not give all the answers, and the answers he gives might not be what we want. Yet, like Habakkuk, we might gain a new understanding of who God is, helping us renew our trust in the one who is in control.

Passages for Further Study

Deuteronomy 29:29; Psalms 47:9; 139:6; 145:3; Isaiah 55:8–9; Daniel 4:25, 35; Habakkuk 1:2–11; 2:2–20; 3:2–19; Acts 17:24–26; Romans 11:33–34; 13:1; Ephesians 1:3–10; Colossians 1:15–20; 2 Peter 3:15

Human Sexuality

When God created the first humans in his own image, he created them male and female (Genesis 1:27). God gave them the ability to have children through their sexuality. This was so they could fill the earth with people and take care of it (1:28). God also created sexuality so that husbands and wives could share deep friendship and closeness in marriage (2:18–25). Being male or female is a basic part of what makes us human. When God looked at everything he had created, including human sexuality, he said it was “very good” (1:31).

Sexual intimacy united the first man and woman as one. It still does today. Biblical sexuality involves the whole person (physical, emotional, and spiritual). It is meant to reflect the union of body and soul within the context of marriage, which is designed for mutual love and commitment. It supports sexual relations only within a permanent commitment to each other's well-being. The Bible describes sexual relations as “knowing” another person intimately (see study note on Genesis 4:1).

Since creation, God intended sexual activity to occur within marriage. Marriage means a permanent and loving commitment between a man and woman (Genesis 1:27–28; 2:23–24). The sexual relationship strengthens the marriage bond and reflects the deep, covenantal union that God designed for husband and wife, with reproduction as one important but not exclusive outcome

Sexuality existed before sin, but human rebellion affected it. Sexuality is powerful and can easily become corrupted if not guided carefully (see Leviticus 18; 1 Thessalonians 4:3–8). Sexual intimacy outside of marriage distorts the order God intended for sexuality. Incest, for example, violates sexual boundaries (see Leviticus 18:7–18). It ruins family structures and harms the community (see Genesis 19:30–38).

Distorted sexuality causes harm and weakens the community (see Genesis 38:1–30; 39:7–9; Judges 19–20). It overemphasizes the individual (see 2 Samuel 13:1–14). But, biblical sexuality strengthens both partners and the community.

Human sexuality was affected when the first humans sinned, leading to brokenness, shame, and distorted desires (Genesis 3). Sin distorts God's good design and leads to the misuse of sexual relations outside of marriage, as well as selfishness and harm in relationships. But God redeemed human sexuality through Jesus Christ's death and resurrection (see 1 Corinthians 6:12–20; Ephesians 5:31–33). He restores sexual wholeness in those who trust in his work by the Holy Spirit (1 Corinthians 6:9–11, 15–20; 1 Thessalonians 4:1–8). Those who commit their sexuality to Christ's work in their lives can demonstrate to others God's love for his people (Ephesians 5:25–33).

Passages for Further Study

Genesis 1:27–28; 2:18–25; Leviticus 18:1–30; Deuteronomy 22:13–29; Ruth 4:11–13; 2 Samuel 11:2–27; Psalm 127:3–5; Ecclesiastes 2:8–11; Song of Solomon 1:8–8:14; Malachi 2:15–16; Matthew 19:3–12; 1 Corinthians 6:12–7:40; Ephesians 5:31–33; 1 Thessalonians 4:3–8